

Title

Randomized Evaluation of Conjoint Gender-Equitable Counseling for Reproductive Health Decision-Making in Rural Couples

Abstract

Family planning programs must balance individual autonomy with couple communication to achieve sustainable contraceptive uptake. This protocol describes a cluster randomized trial designed to test whether training healthcare providers to deliver gender-aware counseling sessions--conducted jointly with married couples and emphasizing shared decision-making--improves reproductive health outcomes compared to routine provision of contraceptive information. We will recruit approximately 1200 married couples from rural communities. Participants randomized to the intervention receive counseling sessions incorporating structured dialogue, equity principles, and client-centered guidance. Control participants receive conventional family planning services. The primary outcome is contraceptive adoption at 9 months. Secondary outcomes assess perceived quality of clinical interactions and couple relationship factors. We hypothesize that the intervention increases contraceptive use through improved quality of care perceived by both partners.